

in 1835, Clara's controlling father did his best to block the relationship. The couple finally married in 1840 after a court ruled that her father's permission was not required. Clara's marriage was loving. Her concert performances continued, and were the family's chief source of income. Despite bearing eight children in 13 years, she found time to compose works such as her substantial Piano Trio of 1846. But her husband's creative ambitions took precedence, and the practical concerns of the household fell on her. When the family was caught up in a violent revolt in Dresden in 1849 (see [box](#)), it was Clara—pregnant as usual—who braved gunfire to rescue three of the children, who had been left in the care of a maid.

Clara's creative drive was above all undermined by a sense of isolation in a male-dominated sphere. "A woman must not desire to compose," she wrote, "there has never yet been one able to do it. Should I expect to be the one?" Her last significant composition, the Three Romances for Violin and Piano, was written in 1853. She was then engulfed in the tragic events of her husband's decline into insanity, which she endured with the support of young composer Johannes Brahms.

Late performances

After Robert's death in 1856, Clara threw herself into concert tours, often performing with the violinist Joseph Joachim, but she no longer composed. Clara is said to have given at least 1,300 performances before declining health curtailed her appearances from the mid-1870s. She outlived four of her children, her son Ludwig dying in an insane asylum like his father. Deaf and